

Babylonian custom which could not have been known to a later Palestinian writer. It is strange that Lenormant should have forgotten—what has often been remarked—that the custom in question, far from being peculiar to Babylon, appears already in Gen. xli., a chapter which, in some respects, bears a striking resemblance to Dan. ii. That the same custom continued in the East long after the Christian era, is well known.

Lenormant likewise claims for the author of Daniel great knowledge as to the details of the organization of the learned and sacerdotal caste (*La Divination*, p. 189). But in reality no details are given. That diviners, magicians, etc., attend upon Nebuchadnezzar, in the book of Daniel, is no matter for surprise, since magicians formed part of the regular *personnel* of an Oriental court, and the magic arts of Babylon, in particular, were celebrated throughout the ancient world. The allusions to these subjects in Daniel imply no special knowledge, but rather the reverse. Thus the learned men of Babylon are in Daniel repeatedly called "*the Chaldeans*," whereas in the cuneiform inscriptions, as in the historical parts of the Old Testament, this is the name of a nation, not of a learned caste¹. And how are we to explain the assertion that Daniel, a strict Jew, was made chief of the heathen sages of Babylon (chaps. ii. 48, iv. 6)? It is amusing to observe that while Pusey has proved to his own satisfaction the credibility of this statement (*Daniel*, pp. 424 ff.), Lenormant, whose acquaintance with ancient Babylon was unquestionably superior to Pusey's, tells us that the position here assigned to Daniel is *evidently* impossible, and he proceeds to get over the difficulty by the usual expedient of supposing that the passages in question are interpolations (*La Divination*, p. 219).

It has also been stated that the presence of women at feasts (Dan. v. 2) is a custom characteristic of Babylon. This may be perfectly true, but it is a custom which survived for centuries

¹ As to the term "Chaldeans" Prof. Schrader observes, "The signification *wise men* that we meet with in the Book of Daniel, is foreign to Assyrio-Babylonian usage and did not arise

till after the fall of the Babylonian empire. This is in itself a clear indication of the post-exilic date of the Book of Daniel." *Cuneif. Inscr.* p. 429.

after the overthrow of the old Babylonian Empire, as is proved by the testimony of Quintus Curtius (v. 1). And if the custom was known to a Roman writer who probably lived under Vespasian, why should it not have been known to a Palestinian writer who lived centuries earlier?

Another Babylonian practice mentioned in Daniel is the punishment of burning alive (chap. iii.). But since, in Jer. xxix. 22, Nebuchadnezzar is described as *roasting* offenders *in the fire*, and since this very chapter is elsewhere quoted by the author of Daniel (chap. ix. 2; cf. Jer. xxix. 10), there can be no difficulty in explaining whence his knowledge was derived.

Thus it will be seen that one proof after another breaks down, and it would be a waste of time to discuss arguments still more fanciful, of which a large and varied collection has been made by Mr Fuller in the *Speaker's Commentary*.

The result of this chapter has hitherto been mainly negative. We have seen that there is no external testimony to the Book of Daniel before the middle of the 2nd century before Christ, and that the narrative of Daniel is seriously at variance with the history of the period in which Daniel is represented as living. But it is fortunately possible for us to advance from negative to positive conclusions. It can be shewn that external evidence and internal evidence both point in the same direction, or in other words that the first half of the 2nd century before Christ—after which period the external testimony begins—is the only period which will explain the contents of the book.

The Book of Daniel is divided into two parts; the first consists of a series of narratives, the second of a series of prophetic visions. In the narratives Daniel is always mentioned in the third person, whereas in the visions he is himself the speaker. The narratives are evidently intended to be consecutive, in point of time, but they are very loosely connected with each other. Their most marked feature is the didactic purpose which appears throughout. In every one of these stories we see the righteous rewarded or the wicked signally punished, as the case may be. On the one hand Daniel and

his three friends, the servants of the True God, though apparently helpless in the midst of the heathen, triumph over all opposition, while on the other hand the mightiest Gentile potentates are confounded and humbled to the dust. This would in itself suffice to indicate that the book was intended for the encouragement of the Jews at a time when they were being persecuted by Pagan rulers. And when we pass from the narratives to the visions, we find that this view is confirmed. For in the visions the final victory of the "Saints" over the Gentile powers is repeatedly insisted upon. Further examination shews that this victory of the Saints is to take place in the days of a Gentile king who will surpass all his predecessors in wickedness. He will arise out of the Fourth Gentile Empire, the Empire of the Greeks, and after cruelly persecuting the Jews he will be destroyed by a divine judgment. Thereupon God will set up an everlasting kingdom. It is especially important to observe that in these visions very little is said about the first three Gentile Empires, while the history of the Fourth is described at great length, and with increasing minuteness as we approach the time of "the king" whose crimes are so vividly set before us. Thus everything combines to shew that the Book of Daniel is, from beginning to end, an exhortation addressed to the pious Israelites in the days of the great religious struggle under Antiochus Epiphanes¹.

It is however necessary to guard against a possible misconception. Though the author of Daniel has everywhere the

¹ One of the latest commentators, Prof. Meinhold, in the *Kurzgefasster Kommentar*, has endeavoured to shew that while chaps. i. and viii.—xii. were composed in the time of Antiochus Epiphanes, chaps. ii.—vi. are the work of a Jew who lived about 300 B.C., and have as their object the conversion of the Gentiles to Judaism. Prof. Meinhold discovers various "contradictions" between the two sets of chapters, but his arguments are extremely fanciful. His theory is examined and,

in my opinion, completely refuted by Budde in the *Theologische Literaturzeitung* for 1888, No. 26 (see the review of Meinhold's *Beiträge zur Erklärung des Buches Daniel*). Here it is enough to say that Prof. Meinhold commits the fundamental error of assuming that a writer of the Maccabean age would necessarily make the situation of Daniel and his companions similar in every detail to the situation of the Jews under Antiochus.